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Introduction

Hello, dear friends! My name is Genndy Bogdanov. I'm the editor and compiler of these materials, a teacher of Russian as a foreign language, and a lifelong language learner myself.

In this introduction, I would like to share with you the methods and ideas that have helped both me and my students learn foreign languages more effectively through reading.

Don't worry if you don't understand everything right away. I promise that by reading the story with translation and commentary, you'll grasp the overall meaning — and if some details remain unclear, that's perfectly fine! Just keep going, and over time, Russian texts will feel more and more familiar.

Remember that language proficiency includes not only reading but also writing, listening, and speaking. That is why this learning pack also includes an audio version of the story.

When I study foreign languages, I do the following: I read a text (and reread it several times!), and once I can understand at least 80% of it without translations or hints, I begin listening to the audio version. Don't worry if you can read a story easily but struggle to understand it by ear. This only means that your ears are still adjusting to the new and unfamiliar sounds of the language. The key is consistency: listen every day, and with each listen, more and more details will become clear.

To practice pronunciation, play the audio version and repeat the sentences after the narrator. When you can understand at least 80% of the audio, return to the written text and try reading it aloud — clearly, confidently, and with proper intonation. Compare yourself with the audio narrator so you can correct mistakes early.

Keep in mind that learning any language is a long journey — and it shouldn't be exhausting. Read a little at a time. Don't try to read as much as possible in one sitting unless it genuinely brings you pleasure.

And here is the greatest secret of everyone who has ever mastered a foreign language: study every day. Start small — even five minutes a day is enough. Gradually increase this time to a comfortable amount, and one day you'll be surprised to find yourself spending hours reading interesting books, watching movies, or chatting with friends in Russian.

Finally, don't give up — and you will certainly master the Russian language. Knowing another language is not only a great reason to be proud of yourself, but also an opportunity to connect with another culture and even develop a new side of your personality. All of this will enrich your thinking and broaden your horizons.

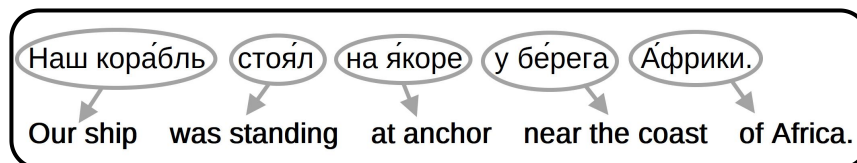
I wish you every success in your study of Russian!

How to Use These Materials

The story is presented in two versions. The first version includes the story along with a translation, commentary, stress marks, grammar explanations, and exercises. The second version presents the same story in its original form, without any hints. After becoming comfortable with the first version, you can move on to the second one to read the story naturally, without guidance.

Translation

Let us look at an example of how one of the sentences is translated:



In this story, each sentence is provided with a word-by-word translation shown in bold type. This means that the word order in the translation exactly matches the word order of the original Russian sentence.

In addition, the translation may include text in parentheses, written in regular (non-bold) type, which is not directly linked to any specific words in the Russian sentence. For example:

- 1) Text marked with an equals sign (=) explains how a Russian phrase or an entire sentence would be translated into natural, grammatically correct English.

Ко́тят бы́ло пять.

Kittens were five. (= There were five kittens.)

- 2) Text without an equals sign provides additional clarification of the meaning of the Russian sentence.

В до́мике бы́ло две ко́мнаты: одна́ ку́хня, друго́я спа́льня.

In the little house (there) were two rooms: one (was) a kitchen, the other a bedroom.

Please note that the punctuation of the original Russian sentence is fully preserved in the English translation.

Commentary

Many sentences are accompanied by brief comments explaining aspects of Russian grammar. If any comment is unclear to you, there is no need to worry — simply continue reading. With experience, you will begin to understand more and more.

Exercises

After reading the story, you will find exercises. The answers to the exercises are provided at the end of the materials.

Audio

Don't forget to use the included audio recordings to improve your listening skills.

Basic Grammar for Reading

Please remember that you don't need to know grammar in advance in order to start reading. Simply read the text, and many grammatical structures will become clear to you naturally with experience.

Stress Marks

Stress marks are small lines placed above letters to show which syllable is stressed. You will see stress marks in almost every word in the first version of the story:

Лебе́дь спусти́лся на́_воду и сложи́л кры́лья.

Basic rules of stress placement:

1) Only vowels can carry stress. In Russian, these are:

а, я, о, ё, у, ю, ы, и, э, е.

2) If a word contains only one vowel, the stress falls on that vowel. In such words, the stress mark is not shown. Don't worry, students usually have no pronunciation problems with these words.

3) In Russian, a word usually has only one stress. A single word (even a very long one!) almost never has two or more stresses.

4) Stress always falls on the letter ё, so in words containing this letter, the stress mark is not shown.

5) Very rarely, you may encounter a situation where two or more words share a single stress. These words are pronounced without a pause, as if they were one word with one stress. In the text, such word combinations are joined with an underscore.

Imperfective and Perfective Verb Aspects

In Russian, verbs are divided into two aspects: imperfective and perfective.

For example:

есть (imperfective) – to be eating OR to eat

съесть (perfective) – to eat up

The imperfective aspect describes a process where the result is unknown or not emphasized:

1) an action that lasts over a period of time.

Сего́дня они́ **ели́** сли́вы. → Today they were eating plums.

2) an action that happens regularly (every day, week, etc.).

Ка́ждый день они́ **ели́** сли́вы. → Every day they ate plums.

The perfective aspect describes a result — a single completed action:

Они́ **съе́ли** все сли́вы. → They ate up all the plums.

In the grammar blocks throughout the stories, verbs are often written in pairs, like this: есть / съесть. The first verb is imperfective, and the second is perfective.

Russian Cases in Brief

Cases are a grammatical category that shows the role a word (noun, pronoun, or adjective) plays in a sentence by changing its ending. When the ending changes, the meaning and grammatical function of the word change accordingly.

Russian cases help us understand who does what, to whom, with what, and where, expressing grammatical relationships that in English are typically indicated by prepositions such as **to**, **of**, and **by**, as well as by fixed word order.

The following table shows how the meanings expressed by Russian cases correspond to the ways these ideas are conveyed in English.

Case	Main Use	Prepositions	Questions	Examples
1 Nominative Именительный	To name the subject (the performer of the action)	Used without prepositions	кто? (who?) что? (what?)	Мать купила слив Кровати стояли там The mother bought plums The beds stood there
2 Genitive Родительный	To express possession or absence	от, до, из, с, для, без, у, около, возле, вокруг, после	кого? (of whom?) чего? (of what?) откуда? (where from?)	Шляпа мальчика На палубе корабля Девочка ушла из дома Нет сливы The boy's hat On the ship's deck The girl left home There is no plum
3 Dative Дательный	To show the indirect object (used with verbs like "to give," "to call," "to help")	к, по	кому? (to whom?) чему? (to what?)	Дать сливы детям Она пришла к дому To give plums to the children She came to the house
4 Accusative Винительный	To show the direct object (the receiver of the action)	в, на, про, через, под, за	кого? (of whom?) что? (what?) куда? (where to?)	Они кормили котёнка Девочка увидела тарелки Они прыгнули в море They were feeding a kitten The girl saw the plates They jumped into the sea
5 Instrumental Творительный	To show the instrument or means	с, за, под, над, между, перед	кем? (by whom?) чем? (by what?)	Стул с подушкой Он подбежал с собаками A chair with a cushion He ran up with the dogs
6 Prepositional Предложный	To indicate location. Never used without a preposition	в, на, о	о ком? (about whom?) о чём? (about what?) где? (where?)	Они рассказали о котёнке Он подумал о сливе Она заблудилась в лесу They talked about the kitten He thought about the plum She got lost in the forest

Мужик и водяной
(The Peasant and the Water Spirit)



Мужи́к¹ урони́л топо́р в ре́ку.

A peasant¹ dropped an axe into the river.

1) мужчи́на – *man*

мужи́к – *historically, the word referred to a male peasant or rural worker. In modern Russian, it is an informal word meaning “man,” “guy,” or “bloke.” It can also be used approvingly to mean “a real man.” Depending on the context, it may sound neutral, friendly, rough, approving, or dismissive.*

С го́ря сел² на бе́рег³ и стал пла́кать.

From grief (= out of grief) he sat down² on the bank³ and began to cry.

2) саді́ться / сесть – *to sit down*

3) бе́рег – *shore, bank*

Водяно́й⁴ услы́шал его́, пожале́л⁵ мужика́, вы́тащил⁶ ему́ из реки́ золоти́й топо́р и говори́т⁷: «Это твой топо́р?»

The Water Spirit⁴ heard him, took pity⁵ on the peasant, pulled⁶ to him (= for the peasant) a gold axe out of the river and says⁷: “This your axe?” (= Is this your axe?)

1) *In Russian fairy tales and folk stories, “водяно́й” is a supernatural being who lives in rivers, lakes, ponds, or swamps. He is often imagined as an old man or a strange male water spirit. Sometimes he helps people, but in many stories he can also be dangerous.*

2) жале́ть / пожале́ть – *to take pity on; to regret*

3) тащи́ть – *to drag*

выта́скивать / вы́тащить – *to drag out, to pull out*

4) *In Russian stories, the present tense is often used inside a past-tense narrative to make the scene feel more vivid and immediate.*

Мужи́к говори́т: «Нет, не мой».

The peasant says: “No, not my (axe).” (= No, it is not mine.)

Водяно́й вы́тащил друго́й, серебра́ный топо́р.

The Water Spirit pulled out another (axe), a silver axe (= a silver one).

Мужи́к о́пять говори́т: «Не мой топо́р».

The peasant again says: “(It is) Not my axe.”

Тогда́ водяно́й вы́тащил о́чень просто́й¹ и ста́рый топо́р.

Then the Water Spirit pulled out a very plain¹ and old axe.

1) просто́й – *simple, plain*

Мужи́к говори́т: «Вот² э́то мой топо́р».

The peasant says: “Exactly² this my axe.” (= This one is my axe.)

2) ВОТ

- *It often means “here is,” “here are,” “there is,” or “look,” and is used to draw attention to someone or something.*
- *Sometimes it means “so” or “well” especially at the beginning of a statement.*
- *It can also be used for emphasis and may sometimes correspond to “indeed.”*
- *But when “Вот” is followed by words like “э́то,” “здесь,” or “так,” it simply reinforces them and can be roughly translated as “exactly.”*

Водяной подарил¹ мужику все три топора за его честность.

The Water Spirit gave as a gift¹ to the peasant all three axes for his honesty.

1) дава́ть / дать – *to give*
дари́ть / подарить – *to give as a gift*
пода́рок – *present, gift*

Remember that the person toward whom the following actions are directed is expressed in the Dative case: “дава́ть” (to give), “звони́ть” (to call by phone), “отправля́ть” (to send), “дари́ть” (to give as a gift).

Examples:

Я подарил дру́гу пода́рок.
I gave (as a gift) to the friend a present.
Meaning: I gave my friend a present.

Водяной подарил топор мужику́.
The Water Spirit gave (as a gift) an axe to the peasant.
Meaning: The Water Spirit gave an axe to a peasant.

Here, “друг” and “мужик” are in the Dative case because they refer to the recipients of the gifts.

До́ма² мужи́к показáл това́рищам³ топоры́ и рассказáл, что с ним бы́ло.

At home² the peasant showed to friends³ (= showed his friends) the axes and told (them), what with him was (= what had happened to him).

2) дом – *house, home*
до́ма – *an adverb of place. It is used when answering the question “где?” (where?) and means “at home.”*

3) това́рищ – *comrade (depending on the context, it can mean “friend,” or “companion.”)*

Вот оди́н¹ мужи́к задума́л то же са́мое² сде́лать: пошёл к реке́, специа́льно броси́л свой топо́р в во́ду, сел на бе́рег и запла́кал³.

So one¹ peasant decided the same² (thing) to do: (he) went to the river, deliberately threw his axe into the water, sat down on the bank and started crying³.

1) оди́н мужи́к – *literally, “one peasant.”*

Here it means “one of the peasants.”

2) то же = то же са́мое – *the same (thing)*

Don’t confuse it with “тоже,” which means “too.”

3) пла́кать – *to cry*

запла́кать – *to start crying*

Водяно́й вы́тащил золоти́й топо́р и спроси́л: «Твой э́то топо́р?»

The Water Spirit pulled out a gold axe and asked: “Your this axe?” (= Is this your axe?)

Мужи́к обра́довался⁴ и закрича́л: «Мой, мой!»

The peasant became glad⁴ and shouted: “My (axe), my (axe)!”

(= The peasant was delighted and shouted, “It’s mine! It’s mine!”)

4) ра́доваться – *to be glad, to be delighted*

обра́доваться – *to become glad*

Водяной не¹ отдал² ему³ ни³ золотого топора, ни его³ собственного, потому что мужик сказал неправду.

The Water Spirit didn't¹ give him back² neither³ the gold axe, nor his own (axe), because the peasant had told an untruth (= the peasant had lied).

1) *In Russian, negative words that start with “ни-” (such as “никто́” (nobody, no one), “никогда́” (never), “ничего́” (nothing), etc.) as well as the particle “ни,” are used together with the particle “не” before the verb, whenever a verb is present:*

Никто́ не знаёт

Nobody not knows.

Meaning: Nobody knows.

Водяной **не** отдал ему³ **ни** золотого топора, **ни** его³ собственного.

The Water Spirit didn't give him back neither the gold axe nor his own.

Meaning: The Water Spirit gave him back neither the gold axe nor his own.

2) **отдать** – *to give away, to give back, to hand over*
[**дать** – *to give*]

3) **ни...**, **ни...** – *neither... nor...*

Мужик и водяной

Мужик уронил топор в реку. С горя сел на берег и стал плакать.

Водяной услышал его, пожалел мужика, вытащил ему из реки золотой топор и говорит: «Это твой топор?» Мужик говорит: «Нет, не мой».

Водяной вытащил другой, серебряный топор. Мужик опять говорит: «Не мой топор».

Тогда водяной вытащил очень простой и старый топор. Мужик говорит: «Вот это мой топор». Водяной подарил мужику все три топора за его честность.

Дома мужик показал товарищам топоры и рассказал, что с ним было.

Вот один мужик задумал то же самое сделать: пошёл к реке, специально бросил свой топор в воду, сел на берег и заплакал.

Водяной вытащил золотой топор и спросил: «Твой это топор?» Мужик обрадовался и закричал: «Мой, мой!» Водяной не отдал ему ни золотого топора, ни его собственного, потому что мужик сказал неправду.